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Setting everything
to its pointiest turns
the M3 Touring into a
proper sports car.

Road test: BMW M3 Touring

Nile Bijoux

When I drove the current BMW M3 Competition Sedan in 2021, I really liked it. It was a breath of fresh air with its rear-wheel-drive layout in a world of complex all-wheel-drive systems and it offered a fantastic helping of power with a true-blue BMW twin-turbo straight six up front.

A year later, and BMW dropped something of a surprise: it actually built a wagon version of the M3, something it has flirted with over the years but never committed to.

We've seen prototypes of older M3s with a larger boot, but nothing has ever come of them. The M3 Touring Competition got the same bones as the M3 Sedan, including the platform and engine, but added xDrive all-wheel drive to the mix as well as the obvious change of a larger boot.

This one here is actually the slightly updated version, with the changes predominantly visual. The front and rear lights look a little different and the cabin has been slightly updated, but BMW has also tweaked the engine to push 390kW, up from the previous 375kW. Torque is the same 650Nm as before.

With more of the M3's performance chops as well as added practicality, did BMW nail the idea of the performance, do-it-all station wagon?

It's so close. But it's not quite perfect. Let's start with the performance part.

That S58 engine is one of the best on the market now in terms of high-performance stuff. More than 500 horsepower in old money is borderline unnecessary for a family machine, but the M3 Touring makes it work. The car never feels like it's straining at the leash, as the numbers might make it seem, it's actually quite docile when left to its own devices.

But pushing the various adjustable parameters into Sports or Sports Plus turns it into a real snarling beast of a thing, opening up the quad exhaust pipes to maximum volume (with a bit of piped-in fakery), holding gears for longer to keep the engine within its chunky powerband,



The interior of the M3 Touring is superb, blending tech with analogue buttons.

The M3 Touring is only available with xDrive all-wheel drive.

MATTHEW HANSEN/STUFF

and sending more of that oomph rearward. Hitting 100kph takes a silly 3.6 seconds, and it'll keep pulling long beyond that speed as well.

The steering gets heavier too, not too heavy though. I do wish M went a bit further in that regard since this is a variable rack and it could have tweaked the ratios in Sports to give a more direct, linear feel to the wheel. It's still very communicative, however, at least about as much as possible in the world of electric steering. You always have a good idea of what the front wheels are doing.

While I wish the M3 Touring retained the RWD architecture of that initial M3 Sedan, because it saves weight and is better for driving, xDrive is very good these days and can allow enough rear-end slippage to make you feel like a hero without letting you see exactly how many aphids are on that tree near the road.

Plus, you get more assurance in low-speed, low-traction conditions and that's what people seem to want these days.

All in, the Touring Comp decimates corners in a way I haven't seen from a wagon. The Audi RS 4 is very good, but quite dated now and the more regimented quattro all-wheel drive system pushes more power to the front than the M3 Touring (maximum of 80% to the rear for the Audi, up to 100% rearward for the



BMW), which translates into a slightly more understeery drive. Plus, the Bimmer outguns the Audi by about 90kW and 50Nm.

Setting the TC into Sports mode dials it back just a smidge to feel really RWD but with a hint of power going frontwards when needed, which makes the M3 Touring that much more playful. You still need your wits about you; this is a powerful car, but it knows how to have a good time. If you really want, you can turn TC off altogether and set the car into RWD mode properly, but you should be on a track for that.

I also really like the interior, particularly compared with other current BMWs such as the M5. The old-school gear selector is lovely to use and, while the steering wheel has more buttons, they feel better under your thumbs. Comfort seats are indeed comfortable and more appropriate for the Touring than the cossetting carbon buckets.

Plus, the operating system here actually remembers my phone and didn't need reconnecting every time I got in, and that larger rear end means you've got 500 litres of storage available with the seats up. But there's still those naff plastic gear-change paddles.

My only real complaint is the ride. It's just too stiff in Comfort to be a family

machine, too bouncy over the often rough Auckland roads. The adaptive suspension does well in Sports modes when you're thrashing it, and arguably that's what M should have focused on, but a wagon needs to do everything, which includes the school run and relaxed family holidays. If BMW toned the firmness down a notch or two, it'd be there.

The efficiency is also a bit grim, with the claimed 10.4L/100km figure optimistic in my testing. Real world, you're looking at north of 12L/100km if you drive tamely, more if you've got a heavy right foot. Still it's much better than an equivalent V8, and no worse than an Audi RS 4.

Finally, it costs, as near as makes no difference, \$200k. That's a lot of money, which could get you a very nice BMW X3 M50 for more comfort, more storage, about 70% of the performance, and about \$50k still in the bank.

So the perfect do-it-all wagon? Not quite. But, man, is it a hell of a drive, and, despite the cost premium, infinitely cooler than an X3.

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